



Not every dream you carry was born in you

Because you reach what you wanted and still feel that something is missing.

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This ebook is a self-knowledge resource. It does not replace therapeutic support. If you experience persistent exhaustion or signs of burnout, please seek professional help.

1. You did everything right, and you are still lost

You did everything right.

You studied. You worked. You tried harder than most. You did not wait. You did not complain. You did not procrastinate. On the contrary: you did more, you did better, you did it before anyone asked. You were the first to arrive and the last to leave. The one who never said no. The one who solved things. The one who delivered ahead of schedule. The one who, when others stopped, kept going.

And you achieved things. The job, the promotion, the recognition. Or the project, the business, the reputation. Or the course, the degree, the expertise. You achieved what you set out to do. And according to every rule you were taught, you should feel fulfilled.

But you do not.

You feel a strange emptiness that does not fit your life. A kind of diffuse disappointment with no visible cause. You feel that you did everything right and yet something fundamental went undone. But you do not

know what. And you do not know who to tell, because how do you explain that you have what you wanted and do not feel what you should?

There is a sensation that accompanies this place: exhaustion without arrival. It is not the ordinary tiredness of someone who works hard. It is the tiredness of someone who has been running in one direction for years and, when they finally stop to look around, realizes they do not know where they are. Or why they came here. Or whether they want to continue. They only know they are tired in a way that rest does not fix. Because the tiredness is not in the body (although the body is also exhausted). It is in the soul. It is the tiredness of someone who spent an entire life chasing something that, when finally caught, turns out to be empty.

Some women describe this as a kind of fog. They are inside their life but cannot see it clearly. They move, they function, they produce, but there is a pane of glass between them and what they live. They see everything but touch nothing. They do everything but feel nothing. And when someone asks "are you happy?", the honest answer would be: "I don't know. I no longer know what happiness is. I know what functioning is. I know what producing is. I know what delivering is. But happiness? I am not sure I would recognize it if I found it."

This fog is not depression (although it can look like it). Depression takes away your energy. The fog takes away your clarity. You can have enormous energy (and you probably do, because you are the woman who does too much), but all that energy is directed outward. Toward goals, toward results, toward deliverables. Nothing is left for the inside. And inside, the fog settles in.

And there is a symptom that is rarely discussed but may be the most revealing of all: the inability to rest. Not the lack of time to rest. The inability. When you have a free afternoon, you do not know what to do with yourself. When there is nothing to solve, you feel anxious. When someone tells you to relax, you feel more tension, not less. Because for you, stopping is not rest. Stopping is a threat. Because if you stop, what appears? The void. And the void is the thing you run from most.

But the void is not the enemy. The void is the message. It is your interior telling you: "There is a space here. A space not filled by any achievement, any goal, any result. And this space asks for something different. It asks you to look inward. It asks you to ask: what is truly mine?"

And the worst part is the guilt. The guilt of not being satisfied. The guilt of having "everything" and wanting "more." The guilt of looking at your life and thinking: "This should be enough. Why isn't it enough?"

And the shame of feeling this, because there are people with infinitely harder lives who seem more at peace than you.

I know this woman. I know her because I see her every day in my work. And I know her because I was her for many years. The woman who does too much. Who has too much talent and too little clarity. Who is competent at everything except knowing what she truly wants. Who runs, and runs, and runs, and when someone asks "where to?", goes blank.

Women come to me with this exact phrase: "I don't know what I'm missing." And they say it with shame. As if not knowing were more proof that they are not enough. But the truth is that not knowing is the most honest symptom they can have. Because what is missing has no easy name. It is not the job, not the money, not the relationship. What is missing is deeper: it is the connection between what you do and who you are. The connection between your life and your truth. And that connection broke so long ago that you no longer remember what it felt like.

And the strangest thing is that the woman who lives this way does not stop. She does not give up. She does not lie on the sofa watching series (although sometimes she desperately wants to). She keeps going. She wakes up, functions, executes, delivers, solves, repeats. With a frightening efficiency. And from the outside, she looks like the most organized

woman in the world. Inside, she is crumbling. Not dramatically. Silently. Like a house that looks impeccable from the outside but whose foundations are giving way, slowly, without anyone seeing.

This woman does not need more motivation. She has too much. She does not need more discipline. She is too disciplined. She does not need more goals. She has too many goals. What she needs is something no one has ever given her: permission to stop and ask "why?" Not "how?" Not "when?" "Why?" Why do I do what I do? For whom? Where does this urgency come from? Whose dream is this?

If you recognize yourself here, I want to tell you something no one told me: it is not ingratitude. It is not lack of effort. It is not lack of anything. It is excess. Excess of directions that are not yours. Excess of dreams that were not born in you. Excess of life lived outward when what you needed was to look inward.

There is a cruel irony in this: you are the woman who does everything right and who for that reason is never questioned. No one stops you and says: "Wait, are you sure you want this?" Because you are so competent, so effective, so impressive in your results, that no one questions the direction. They question the results of those who fail. Not those who win. And you win. Always. But you win in a game that may not even be yours.

And the question that can save you is not "how do I do more?" Nor "how do I do better?" It is: "What am I doing this for? Whose dream is this? Who decided this was what I should pursue?" If these questions cause you discomfort, that is a good sign. Discomfort is the signal that you are touching something true.

And that is what this book is about. Not about doing more. Not about doing better. About stopping. And asking, perhaps for the first time: whose dreams am I carrying?

2. Achieving and feeling little

Let me describe a scene for you. If it is not exactly yours, it will be close enough that you recognize it.

You have been working toward something for months. A project, a goal, an objective. You gave everything. Nights, weekends, energy you did not have. You sacrificed things: time with your children, health, sleep, leisure, presence. And finally it happens. The project is approved. The goal is reached. The email arrives. The result appears.

And you feel... little.

Not nothing. There is a brief moment of satisfaction. A relief. An "I did it." Perhaps a smile, perhaps a toast, perhaps a post on social media with the right hashtag. But beneath that, almost immediately, something begins to stir. A familiar discomfort. A restlessness you know well, because you have felt it before. At the last achievement. And the one before that. And the one before that.

"All right. And now?"

And the "now" is always the next goal. The next milestone. The next step. Because if you stop, if you stay here, with this achievement, without the next one already in sight, the void appears. And the void is unbearable. So you run. Again. To the next one. And the next. And the next.

There is a name for this in psychology: the hedonic treadmill. We have spoken about it in another book. But here I want to go deeper. Because the hedonic treadmill explains the mechanism (we get used to what we achieve and want more), but it does not explain the root. It does not explain why YOU, specifically, run. Why YOUR treadmill spins so fast. Why YOUR satisfaction lasts so little.

And the root is this: you do not want the goal. You want what the goal promises.

Stop. Read again. You do not want the goal. You want what you believe the goal will give you.

The promotion is not about the title. It is about feeling that you are worth something. The money is not about the account. It is about feeling safe. The recognition is not about the applause. It is about feeling that you belong. The productivity is not about the to-do list. It is about feeling that you deserve to exist.

Beneath every goal you pursue, there is a need. And the need is legitimate: recognition, security, worth, belonging, sufficiency. These are human needs, deep, real. Everyone has them. This is not weakness. It is humanity.

The problem is not the need. The problem is the vehicle. Because the vehicle is external and the need is internal. The vehicle is temporary and the need is permanent. The vehicle is visible and the need is invisible. And when you use something visible and temporary to address something invisible and permanent, the result is always the same: it works a little, then fails, and you need more.

It is the same mechanism as addiction. I am not saying you are a workaholic (although you may be). I am saying the mechanism is the same: there is an internal pain, there is an external substance that briefly relieves that pain, and there is the growing need for more substance to achieve the same effect. In the case of classic dependency, the substance is alcohol, or food, or shopping. In your case, the substance is achievement. Productivity. Results. Validation. And because these "substances" are socially applauded (no one will say to you "you work too much" the way they say "you drink too much"), the dependency goes unnoticed. It is the most invisible and most rewarded addiction that exists. You are

trying to satisfy an internal need with an external achievement. And the external achievement, however brilliant, never reaches the place where the need lives.

It is like being thirsty and eating. The food can be wonderful. But the thirst continues. And you, instead of looking for water, eat more. And more. And more. And the thirst continues. And you do not understand why, because you are so busy eating that you do not stop to ask: "Wait. What do I actually need?"

The woman who lives this is not weak, not foolish, not ungrateful. She is, in most cases, extraordinarily competent. She has too much talent and too little clarity. She knows how to do everything except one thing: know what she truly wants. Because no one ever taught her to ask. They taught her to execute. And she executes brilliantly. But executes what? For whom? For what?

There is a scene I see frequently that illustrates this mechanism perfectly. A woman receives good news (a promotion, a contract, public recognition). And instead of celebrating, the first thing she does is think about the next step. Before even feeling the joy of the achievement, she is already planning the next one. As if stopping and feeling were dangerous. As if joy were a distraction from what really matters: the next goal.

This inability to feel the achievement is the clearest sign that it is not the achievement you are looking for. If it were, you would feel it. You would stay with it. You would linger in it. But because what you are truly looking for is something else (recognition, security, worth, sufficiency), and the achievement does not reach that place, the body does not even bother to celebrate. It knows, intuitively, that this is not it. And it pushes you toward the next attempt.

I know a woman (I will call her Sofia) who had on the wall of her office a list of goals. Each year, she added new ones. And each year, she crossed off the ones she had reached. And the list never shrank. Because each crossed-off goal generated two new ones. Sofia looked at the wall and felt pride and despair in equal measure. Pride for what she had achieved. Despair because she knew, deep down, that none of those crossed-off lines had given her what she truly wanted. And what she truly wanted was not on the list. It had no name. It could not be crossed off. Because it was not a goal. It was a need. And needs are not solved with lists. They are solved with truth.

There is another signal that most people ignore: selective envy. Not generic envy (of those who have more than you). Surgical envy, which appears when someone does something specific that touches you. The colleague who left the corporate career and opened a ceramics studio, and

you feel a sting. The friend who went to live in the countryside and you feel a wave of nostalgia for something you never lived. The stranger on social media who wrote a book and you feel, for a moment, something that is not envy: it is recognition. It is your true self waving and saying: "Look! That is more like me than this I am living!"

Selective envy is a compass in disguise. It does not show you what you should have. It shows you what you truly want. And if you pay attention to what gives you that sting (not the broad envy, the specific sting), you will find clues about your genuine desires. The ones that were buried beneath the borrowed ones.

If you have arrived here and feel that I am describing something you know, stay. Because what comes next may change the way you look at everything you have pursued until now.

3. You do not want the goal, you want what it promises

This is the central chapter of this book. If you are only going to read one, let it be this one.

Substitution is the most silent and most effective mechanism I know. It works like this: there is something you lack (recognition, security, worth, belonging, sufficiency). This lack is old, often so old that you do not even recognize it as a lack. It is the air you breathe. It is the backdrop of your inner landscape. It is always there.

And because this lack is unbearable (because we are beings who need to feel recognized, safe, valuable, belonging, sufficient), your system does something intelligent: it finds a substitute. Something in the external world that, when achieved, promises to fill the lack. A promotion (substitute for recognition). A high salary (substitute for security). Being the best at something (substitute for worth). Belonging to a group, a company, a cause (substitute for belonging). Doing everything perfectly (substitute for sufficiency).

The substitute works. Briefly. Because when you reach the promotion, you feel recognized. For a month. Then the lack returns. Because the promotion filled the substitute, not the need. The recognition you need does not come from a title. It comes from within. It comes from knowing that you are worth something, regardless of what you do. And no title can give you that. No achievement can give you that. Because what you lack is not in the future. It is in the past.

And here is the deepest connection of all, the one that links the Infante to Family Constellation: you are trying to obtain in the future what was missing in the past.

I want you to think about this carefully, because it is the key to everything. You are not running forward. You are running backward. Every goal you pursue is an attempt to go back in time and fill what was left empty. The promotion is the attempt to go back and deserve your father's gaze. The money is the attempt to go back and give security to the child who lived in chaos. The perfection is the attempt to go back and be enough for the mother who never told you that you were.

But you cannot go back. The past already happened. The gaze that never came will not come now, no matter how many promotions you achieve. The security that was missing cannot be bought with money. The

sufficiency you were never given cannot be earned with perfection. These are different things. They live in different dimensions. And as long as you try to resolve one with the other, the running does not stop. Because the goal is in one place and the need is in another. They never meet.

This is not despair. This is liberation. Because when you see that the goal is not the path to the need, you can stop running. Not because you give up on the goal (you can keep it if you want, now by choice, not by compulsion). But because you know that the need requires another path. An inner path. A path not traveled by running. You travel it by stopping. By feeling. By looking at the child who was left behind and saying: I see you. I see what you lacked. And I do not need one more achievement to prove to you that you are worth something. You are worth something. You always were.

The woman who pursues recognition may be the daughter who was never seen by her father. Who did everything to deserve his gaze, his approval, his word. And who never received it. And now, thirty years later, still does everything to deserve gazes, approvals, words. Only now they are the boss's gazes, the market's approvals, the public's words. The stage changed. The play is the same.

The woman who pursues security may be the daughter who grew up in instability. Unstable home, unstable money, unstable emotions. Who learned that the world is not safe and that the only way to protect herself is to control. Control money, work, body, the future. And who now lives in permanent alert mode, accumulating (work, money, skills, insurance), never feeling she has enough. Because the insecurity is not about the present. It is about the child who lived in chaos and who never felt solid ground.

The woman who pursues worth may be the daughter who grew up hearing (explicitly or implicitly) that she was not enough. That her grades could be better. That her sister was prettier. That her cousin was smarter. That "with that behavior you won't get anywhere." And who internalized a measuring stick: I am only worth something if I prove it. And she proves it. Every day. With every project, every delivery, every achievement. But the measuring stick never comes down. The line is always higher. And she never arrives.

The woman who pursues belonging may be the daughter who felt outside. Outside the family, outside the group, outside the mold. Who was "different," "too sensitive," "complicated." Who never found the place where she fit. And who now looks for belonging in everything: the perfect job, the right social circle, the noble cause, the professional

identity. Because belonging is the most primary need of the human being. And whoever did not belong as a child spends adult life trying to belong. And the price is always the same: erasing herself to fit.

The woman who pursues sufficiency may be the daughter who learned that simply being is never enough. That she needs to do in order to deserve. That love is conditional: "if you are a good daughter," "if you get good grades," "if you don't cause problems." And who now lives in permanent performance: being enough is doing enough. And because "enough" has no measure (because the inner measure is broken), she does without stopping. And it is never enough. Never.

Let me give you a concrete example so you can feel how substitution works. Marta (fictional name, real pattern) has worked at a company for eight years. She is excellent at what she does. Everyone knows it. The managers trust her, the colleagues respect her, the clients love her. And for three years she has been waiting for a promotion to director. She does everything to deserve it: stays late, takes on extra projects, resolves crises that are not hers.

And when the promotion finally comes, do you know what she feels? Nothing. I mean, she feels something: a brief relief, a "finally," and then, almost immediately, a question: "And now? What is the next

step?" The promotion lasted one celebration dinner. The next morning, Marta was already thinking about the next role.

When we talked, I asked her: "What did you expect to feel when you were promoted?" She went silent. She thought. And she said: "I expected to finally feel that I was enough." She did not say "I expected to have more responsibility" or "I expected to earn more." She said "enough." And there was the need beneath the goal. Marta did not want the title. She wanted to feel sufficient. And no title could give her that. Because the insufficiency she felt was not professional. It was existential. It came from far back. It came from home. It came from a childhood where "enough" was never enough.

When I asked Marta "how did you know, as a child, that you were not enough?", she went silent for almost a minute. Then she said: "From my mother's expression. When I brought home good grades, she would look and say 'very good.' But her eyes did not say 'very good.' Her eyes said 'that is what is expected.' And I understood that the 'very good' was not celebration. It was confirmation that I had not yet failed. And I lived in fear of failing. Because hearing my mother's 'very good' was all I had. And I knew that if I failed, I would not even have that."

And there was the substitution in its purest form: Marta did not want promotions. She wanted her mother's gaze. She wanted a gaze that said "you are enough, even when you fail." And since she never received it, she spent her life looking for it in other gazes: bosses, clients, colleagues. And none of them could give her what her mother did not. Because it was her mother she needed. And her mother, poor woman, had never received it from her own parents either. And the chain continues.

Family Constellations show us that these chains are generational. The insufficiency was not born in Marta. It was born in the family. It passed from grandmother to mother, from mother to daughter. And it passes not through words, but through gazes, through gestures, through atmospheres. The child does not need to hear "you are not enough" in order to feel it. It is enough to see in the eyes of those she loves that who she is never arrives.

Do you recognize any of these women? Perhaps more than one. Perhaps all of them. Because the needs cross, overlap, feed on each other. And the substitution is so skilled, so automatic, so transparent, that you can live an entire life without realizing you are pursuing substitutes. You think you want the promotion. You think you want the money. You

think you want the perfection. But what you want, what you truly want, is to feel seen, safe, valuable, belonging, sufficient. And no external goal can give you that. None.

4. Pursuing the future to repair the past

There is a phrase I say often and that always provokes the same reaction: a long silence, followed by damp eyes.

The phrase is this: "You are running toward the future to escape the past."

And the reaction is always the same because it is always true. The woman who pursues without stopping, who cannot rest, who feels that stopping is dying, who feels that if she is not doing something she is failing, this woman is not running toward the future. She is running from the past. From an old pain. From an old lack. From a child who was left behind and who is still waiting.

Family Constellations show us something that conventional psychology does not always highlight: we do not only repeat what we lived. We also repeat what we did not live. Voids are inherited just as much as excesses. The mother who had no opportunity to study can produce a daughter who studies compulsively. The father who did not realize his dreams can produce a daughter who pursues dreams that are not hers,

but his. The family that lived in scarcity can produce a generation obsessed with abundance, not out of greed, but out of unconscious loyalty:

"I will achieve what you could not."

And this loyalty is invisible. It is not thought about. It is not decided. It is felt. It is lived in the body. It is the urgency that has no explanation, the ambition that seems natural but never satisfies, the impulse to do more when you have already done enough. It is the engine that will not turn off, even when the fuel is gone.

There is a woman I have been accompanying for some time. I will call her Inês. Inês is an entrepreneur. She built a business from scratch, alone, with enormous effort. The business grew, gained clients, won awards. Inês should be proud. And outwardly, she is. But inwardly, she lives in panic. Panic that everything will disappear. Panic of not being enough. Panic that, at any moment, someone will discover that she "is not that good."

When we looked at Inês's family history, we found something she had never connected to her business: her grandfather. Inês's grandfather had had a business, in the nineteen-sixties. A business that went bankrupt. The family lost everything. The grandfather never recovered. He died poor, bitter, defeated. And Inês's mother grew up in that shadow: the

daughter of the man who failed. And she passed on to Inês, without words, a message: "Never fail. Never lose. Never let what happened to your grandfather happen again."

And Inês obeyed. Without knowing she was obeying. Without anyone ever telling her "you must redeem your grandfather." Her mother never said that. She did not need to. Because family loyalty is not transmitted in words. It is transmitted in gazes, in silences, in sighs, in stories told at the dinner table. Inês grew up hearing about the grandfather who "had everything and lost it." And her body decided, before she was old enough to decide anything at all: I will not let this happen again. She built a business (like her grandfather). She worked without stopping (unlike her grandfather, who "gave up"). She refused to fail (to redeem her grandfather). And the panic she felt was not about her business. It was about her grandfather's business. The pain she carried was not hers. It was from a previous generation. And the dream of success she pursued was not born in her. It was born in the failure of someone who came before.

When Inês saw this, something changed. Not suddenly. Not magically. But deeply. Because for the first time, she could separate: this is mine, this is my grandfather's. And she could choose: I want to continue this

business, but now for myself. Not to redeem anyone. Not to prove anything. For myself.

There is another pattern I see very frequently: the woman who pursues the dreams her mother could not have. The mother who stayed at home, who did not study, who did not travel, who did not have a career, who sacrificed herself for her children. And the daughter, out of loyalty (and out of love, because it is always out of love), decides: I will have everything she did not have. I will study. I will travel. I will have a career. I will be independent. I will be free.

And all of this seems healthy. It seems like emancipation. It seems like freedom. But when you look more closely, you realize the motivation is not freedom. It is rescue. The daughter is trying to save her mother, retroactively, by living the life her mother did not live. And the price is that she never lives her own life. She lives the life her mother should have had. And when she reaches it (the career, the independence, the freedom), she does not feel satisfaction. She feels emptiness. Because it was not for her. It was for her mother. And her mother, poor woman, does not even know.

There is also loyalty to failure. The family where no one "made it." Where success is viewed with suspicion, as betrayal. "Who do you think you are?" The woman who grows up in this family can do one of

two things: either she unconsciously sabotages herself (so as not to surpass the family, not to leave the group, not to betray the belonging), or she pursues success with a compensatory ferocity that wears her down to the bone. In both cases, she is not choosing for herself. She is reacting to the system. And reacting is not the same as choosing.

And there is also loyalty to the era. Each generation inherits not only the dreams of their parents, but the dreams of the time in which they grow up. The generation that grew up hearing "you need a degree" carries that dream as absolute truth, even when the degree no longer guarantees anything it once promised. The generation that grew up with social media carries a measuring stick of visible success, of curated life, of photogenic results, that did not exist before and that contaminates everything. These are era dreams. They seem universal ("everyone wants this"), but they are not. They are the noise of culture overlying the inner voice.

When you look at all of this (inheritance, borrowing, comparison, compensation, era), perhaps you realize that very little remains that is genuinely yours. And that may frighten you. But I want you to know: it is normal. Most women who do this exercise discover that the percentage of goals that are genuinely theirs is much smaller than they expected. And the initial reaction is almost always the same: "Then what is

left?" What is left is the essential. What is left is what is truly yours. And that, however small it may seem, is worth more than everything that is borrowed.

The question you need to ask is not: "What do I want?" (because you have asked that question a thousand times and the answers never satisfied you). The question is: "Whose wanting is this?" And if the answer is not clearly "mine," perhaps you are carrying someone else's dream. Or an era's dream. And you can, with respect and with love, return it.

5. Whose dreams are you carrying

If the previous chapter showed you that you are running from the past, this one asks you to look at what you carry and ask: is it mine?

It is a question that seems simple. But when you ask it for real, when you sit with it and give it time, what you find may surprise you. Because most of the dreams we pursue were not born in us. They arrived from outside. They arrived so early, so silently, that we think they are ours. But they are not. They are borrowed. And there are different kinds of borrowing.

Before I list them, I want you to do something. Think about the three most important goals in your life right now. The ones that occupy your mind, your energy, your time. You do not need to write them down (though it helps). Just have them present. And as you consider them, ask yourself, for each one: "If no one knew I had achieved this, would I still want it? If no one was watching, would I still pursue it?" The answer to this question tells you a great deal. Because if the motivation depends on being seen, the dream is probably not yours. It is a dream that needs an audience. And genuine dreams do not need an audience. They only need you.

There are inherited dreams. The dreams your parents did not realize and that you, out of loyalty, took on as your own. The father who wanted to be a doctor and you studied medicine. The mother who wanted to travel and you have a compulsive need to "see the world." The grandfather who wanted to be free and you cannot tolerate any form of control. These are not your dreams. They are theirs. And you live them as if they were yours, without realizing you are living someone else's life.

There are borrowed dreams. The dreams that society, the era, the group placed before you as "normal" and that you absorbed without questioning. The big house. The new car. The brilliant career. The perfect body. The successful children. The Instagram life. Who decided that this is success? Who defined this measuring stick? Was it you? Or was it the noise around you?

There are comparison dreams. The dreams that are born not from genuine desire, but from observing what others have. The colleague who was promoted and now you "need" to be promoted too. The friend who opened a business and now you feel you should have one. The cousin who lost weight and now your body is a problem. Comparison generates desires that seem yours but are reflections. And pursuing reflections is pursuing shadows.

There are compensation dreams. The dreams born from pain. "If I achieve this, I prove I am not what they said." "If I reach that, my mother will be proud of me." "If I have success, no one will ever be able to say I am not enough." These dreams have a fierce energy, an almost unshakable determination. But they are driven by pain, not desire. And when the goal is reached, the pain continues. Because the goal was not the remedy. It was the bandage.

There is a simple (not easy, but simple) way to distinguish a dream of yours from a borrowed dream: the body. When you pursue something that is genuinely yours, the body expands. You feel energy, not exhaustion. You feel curiosity, not obligation. You feel attraction, not duty. The path may be difficult, but you feel it is YOUR path. When you pursue something borrowed, the body contracts. You feel weight. You feel urgency. You feel that it is never enough. You feel that if you stop, something terrible will happen. The effort is enormous, but the satisfaction is minimal. Because it is not yours. And the body knows.

There is another clue: language. When you talk about something that is yours, you say "I want." When you talk about something borrowed, you say "I have to," "I should," "it is necessary." Notice how you talk about your goals. Are they wanting or obligation? Are they attraction or duty? Are they desire or fear?

There is something I want to say about compensation dreams, because they are the most treacherous. Compensation dreams have a different energy from the others. They are furious. Relentless. They accept no rest. The woman who pursues by compensation does not allow herself to stop, because stopping means feeling the original pain. And the original pain is unbearable: "I was not enough." So she runs. And with each achievement, for a very brief instant, the pain goes quiet. But it comes back. It always comes back. Because the achievement is not the remedy. It is the anesthetic. And the anesthetic wears off.

And there is a hidden cost in all of this: relationships. The woman who pursues without stopping loses, slowly, the people around her. Not because she abandons them (although sometimes she does). But because she is not present. She is running. And whoever runs cannot embrace. Whoever runs cannot listen. Whoever runs cannot stop to look into someone's eyes and say "I am here." And the children feel it. The partner feels it. The friends feel it. Everyone feels it. And they move away. Slowly. In silence. And she, so busy running, only notices when she stops. And when she stops, the emptiness is double: the dreams did not fill her, and the people did not stay.

Now ask yourself: how many of your current goals were born genuinely in you? How many are inheritance, borrowing, comparison, compensation? Not to judge them. To see them. Because as long as you do not see them, you run. And you run without knowing where to. And you arrive without knowing why. And you remain empty.

And there is one type of dream that is perhaps the most dangerous of all: the negative dream. Not the dream of what you want to be, but the dream of what you do not want to be. "I do not want to be like my mother." "I do not want to be poor like my parents." "I do not want to fail like my brother." These dreams seem your own, but they are reactive. They are the negative of someone else. And when you live your life running from being someone, you are not going anywhere. You are fleeing from a place. And fleeing is not the same as walking. Fleeing is exhausting, blind, and never takes you to a place you chose. It only takes you away from another place. And "away from" is not a destination. It is an escape.

And if you like, take a piece of paper right now. Write down your three main goals at this moment. The ones that occupy your mind, your energy, your time. And beside each one, write one word: truth, inheri-

tance, comparison, or compensation. You do not need to be certain. Just an intuition. And notice what you feel as you write. The body knows. The body always knew.

6. Letting go is not giving up

If you have come this far, you may be feeling something strange: relief mixed with terror. Relief because someone finally put words to what you felt. Terror because, if the dreams you pursue are not yours, what is left?

The honest answer is: I do not know. Not yet. And neither do you. And that is all right.

Because letting go is not giving up. Letting go is releasing what is not yours so that your hands are free to hold what is. Letting go is not stopping wanting. It is stopping wanting what does not belong to you. Letting go is not becoming directionless. It is releasing the compass that points toward someone else's destination and staying, for a time, without a compass. And that time without a compass, however uncomfortable it may be, is the most fertile time of your life. Because it is the time when, finally, you can hear your own voice.

And your voice may say things that surprise you. It may say: "I do not want this career. I want another." It may say: "I do not need to prove anything to anyone." It may say: "What I truly want is simpler, quieter, smaller than everything I have built." And these revelations can be

terrifying. Because dismantling what you built (or at least revisiting your relationship with what you built) is frightening. It is frightening because your identity was anchored in your achievements. And without the achievements, who are you?

But that question, "who am I without my achievements?", is exactly the right question. It is the question the Infante asks. Not to take away your achievements. To return you to yourself. So that your achievements are an expression of who you are, not a replacement for what you lack.

The work of letting go is not simple. It is not an afternoon decision. It is a process. A process of returning borrowed ambitions, inherited dreams, other people's expectations. A process of looking at your life and asking, item by item: "Is this mine? Do I want this for myself? Or do I want this to prove something, to compensate for something, to repeat something?"

And that process, done with honesty and with accompaniment, does not leave you empty. It leaves you clean. And in the clean space, what is truly yours can, finally, appear.

I know women who have done this work and describe the feeling as "coming home." Not a physical home. An inner home. A place where they know who they are, without needing to prove it. A place where the

urgency does not exist, where the list does not command, where worth does not depend on results. A place that was always there, beneath everything, but that was buried under years of borrowed achievements and inherited ambitions.

Arriving at that place does not mean stopping working, stopping creating, stopping being ambitious. It means that the work becomes an expression of who you are, not a replacement for what you lack. It means that creation is born from desire, not from duty. It means that the ambition is yours, genuinely yours, and therefore nourishes instead of exhausts.

And there is a difference you feel in the body: when what you do is yours, the tiredness at the end of the day is good. It is the tiredness of someone who lived. When what you do is borrowed, the tiredness at the end of the day is grey. It is the tiredness of someone who functioned.

But I want to be honest about one thing: the process of letting go is not linear. It is not an afternoon decision that holds forever. There are days when you let go with clarity. There are days when you take everything back without noticing. There are days when you hear your voice clearly. There are days when the noise of others is louder. This is normal. It is not failure. It is the rhythm of someone relearning how to listen to themselves after years of listening to others.

And there is a legitimate fear that appears when you begin to let go: the fear of losing your identity. Because if you are not "the woman who achieves everything," who are you? If you are not "the hardest worker," who are you? If you are not defined by your achievements, your resume, your results, who are you? This fear is real. And the honest answer is: I do not know. Not yet. And the courage to say "I do not know" is the starting point.

Because "I do not know" is the empty space where the new can be born. "I do not know" is the blank page where you can, finally, write with your own handwriting, not with the handwriting of your parents, of society, of the era. "I do not know" is not failure. It is freedom. And freedom, at first, looks a great deal like emptiness. But it is not the same thing. Emptiness is absence. Freedom is space.

7. The question that changes everything

There is a question that, when asked with truth, changes the direction of an entire life. It is not a complicated question. It does not require training, or therapy, or permission. It only requires courage.

The question is: "What is truly mine?"

Not "what should I want." Not "what would look good." Not "what do others expect." What is truly mine. What was born in me, not in my father. What I chose, not what I was told to choose. What makes me feel alive (not productive, not efficient, not sufficient: alive).

This question is the starting point of the Infante. Not as an intellectual exercise, but as a crossing. Because the answer does not come from the mind. The mind is trained to give answers that please, that are safe, that make sense. The answer comes from the body. From stillness. From the moment when you stop doing and stay only with yourself, and something whispers (not shouts, whispers) what it has always wanted to tell you.

I want to tell you something about what happens when you ask this question for real. When you sit with it, when you give it space, when you do not rush to answer. What happens, in most cases, is silence. The mind, used to producing instant answers, becomes puzzled. "What is truly mine?" And nothing comes. Or something comes that seems ridiculous, small, insignificant. "I want to draw." "I want to walk." "I want to live near the sea." "I want to have time." And the mind says immediately: "That does not count. That is not a goal. That cannot go on a resume."

But that is exactly where your truth is. In the things the mind discards as "too small." Because your truth does not need to be grand. It does not need to be impressive. It does not need to be validated by anyone. It only needs to be yours. Genuinely yours. And when it is yours, when it is born from you and not from inheritance or comparison or compensation, there is a different quality to the way you live it. You do not live it in a rush. You live it with presence. You do not pursue it with desperation. You walk in it with calm. It does not exhaust you. It nourishes you.

Perhaps what is yours is simpler than you thought. Perhaps it is writing, without publishing. Perhaps it is caring, without a title. Perhaps it is creating, without an audience. Perhaps it is living, without proving. Perhaps what is yours does not fit on a resume. Perhaps it has no name.

Perhaps it has no applause. But when you feel it, you know. Because the body calms. The urgency stops. The treadmill switches off. And you, for the first time in a long time, feel that you have arrived. Not at a destination. At yourself.

There is a woman who told me, after doing this work: "I spent thirty years building a life that looked perfect. And now I look at it and realize it was my mother's perfect life. Not mine. Mine I have not yet begun to live." She was fifty-two years old when she said this. And she was not sad. She was awake. For the first time. And she began. At fifty-two. Without urgency. Without compensation. For truth.

It is never too late to ask the question. "What is truly mine?" Not as yet another self-knowledge exercise. As the question that founds a new life. A life not measured by what you achieved, but by what is truly yours. A life that may be smaller, simpler, quieter than the previous one, but that is yours. Entirely yours. And because it is yours, because it is true, because it is chosen and not inherited, it fills in a way that no list of achievements ever did.

8. Bridge to the Infonte

What this book gave you was a map. A map of the paths that are not yours, of the dreams you carry without knowing whose they are, of the mechanisms that make you run without arriving.

But a map is not a crossing. Seeing is not the same as changing. And between understanding that you pursue what is not yours and beginning to choose what is, there is a path that asks for more than understanding. It asks for accompaniment. It asks for a safe space. It asks for someone who helps you distinguish your voice from the others, return what is borrowed, keep what is yours.

The Infonte was created for that. Not as yet another personal development program. Not as yet another list of goals and objectives. But as the space where you finally stop pursuing and begin choosing. Where you ask "what is truly mine?" and have time, silence, and company to hear the answer.

The Infonte is the sister of the FreeMe. In the FreeMe, you set down what you carry (guilt, weight, loyalties). In the Infonte, you distinguish what you pursue (borrowed ambitions, inherited dreams, substitutes).

Both make the same crossing: returning to what is truly yours. One sets down. The other chooses. Both return you to yourself.

You will find the Infonte at infonte.viviannedossantos.com.

And if what you read helped you realize that you carry not only borrowed dreams but also emotional weight (guilt, invisible loyalties, family patterns), the FreeMe is where that work is done. Infonte and FreeMe are siblings: one sets down what you carry, the other chooses what you pursue. Both return you to yourself. At freeme.viviannedossantos.com.

But before any guided space, stay with the question. Carry it with you. Let it accompany you. "What is truly mine?" And the next time you feel the impulse to run toward the next goal, the next achievement, the next proof that you deserve to exist, stop. Breathe. And ask: "Is this mine? Or am I pursuing someone else's dream?"

The answer may take time. It may not come right away. It may come in fragments, in whispers, in sensations in the body. But it comes. And when it comes, everything changes. Because you stop running. And you begin walking. On your own path. At your own pace. In your own direction.

With all my tenderness, *Vivianne*

This material is a self-knowledge and personal reflection resource. It does not constitute therapeutic, psychological, or medical advice. If you feel persistent exhaustion, signs of burnout, or an inability to stop, please seek professional support. The woman of the Infante does too much: recognizing that is strength, not weakness.

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